

PERSEUS

THE VICTORIOUS HERO

PERSEUS IS A PROMINENT CONSTELLATION OF THE NORTHERN SKY. IT LIES IN THE MILKY WAY BETWEEN ANDROMEDA AND AURIGA, NORTH OF TAURUS THE BULL. PERSEUS FEATURES A TWIN CLUSTER OF STARS AND A FAMOUS VARIABLE STAR, ALGOL.

In Greek myth, Perseus was sent to bring back the head of Medusa the Gorgon, whose gaze turned people to stone. He cut off Medusa's head and was returning home with it when he saw Princess Andromeda chained to a rock as a sacrifice to the sea monster Cetus. Perseus killed Cetus, freed Andromeda, and took her as his bride. The constellations Perseus and Andromeda lie side by side in the night sky.

Perseus is represented holding Medusa's severed head, marked by the variable star Algol in his left hand. Algol is a binary, in which the fainter star eclipses the brighter one every 2.9 days, causing it to fade for 10 hours.

Perseus is the source of the annual Perseid meteor shower, which radiates from the north of the constellation, near the border with Cassiopeia, in mid-August each year.

In 1901, **Nova Persei** erupted to become one of the **brightest stars** in the sky for several days before gradually fading away

▷ **NGC 869 and NGC 884**
Known as the Double Cluster, these twin open clusters are visible to the naked eye as a brighter patch in the Milky Way near the border with Cassiopeia. NGC 869 (left in the image) is the brighter and richer of the pair. They lie about 7,000 light-years away.



△ **M76**
The double-lobed shape of this planetary nebula gives it its popular name: the Little Dumbbell. At 10th magnitude, M76 is the faintest object in Charles Messier's catalog of deep-sky objects.



△ **GK Persei**
The explosion of Nova Persei threw off a glowing shell of hot gas, resulting in the nova remnant known as GK Persei (also sometimes called the Firework Nebula).

KEY DATA

Size ranking 24

Brightest stars Mirphak (α) 1.8, Algol (β) 2.1–3.4

Genitive Persei

Abbreviation Per

Highest in sky at 10pm
November–December

Fully visible 58°N–83°S



CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Mirphak Alpha (α) Persei
Also spelled Mirfak, a white supergiant
☼ 1.8 ↔ 500 light-years

Algol Beta (β) Persei
An eclipsing binary star with variable brightness
☼ 2.1–3.4 ↔ 90 light-years

Gamma (γ) Persei
A yellow giant
☼ 2.9 ↔ 240 light-years

Delta (δ) Persei
A blue giant
☼ 3.0 ↔ 520 light-years

Epsilon (ε) Persei
A blue giant
☼ 2.9 ↔ 640 light-years

Zeta (ζ) Persei
A blue supergiant and Perseus's third-brightest star
☼ 2.9 ↔ 750 light-years

Rho (ρ) Persei
A variable red giant
☼ 3.3–4.0 ↔ 310 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Alpha Persei Cluster
A scattered cluster of stars around Mirphak

GK Persei
The Nova Persei remnant, also called the Firework Nebula

M34
A large open cluster of about 60 stars

M76
A planetary nebula, known as the Little Dumbbell

NGC 869 and NGC 884
Twin open clusters, known as the Double Cluster

NGC 1499
An emission nebula, known as the California Nebula

Perseus A (NGC 1275)
A supergiant elliptical galaxy